ABSTRACT

THE USE OF SCIENCE IN THEOLOGY:

INTRODUCTION AND HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

by

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Adviser: John A. Smith, Ph.D.

ABSTRACT OF GRADUATE STUDENT RESEARCH

Professional Dissertation

Andrews University

Seventh-day Adventist Theological Seminary

Title: THE USE OF SCIENCE IN THEOLOGY:
INTRODUCTION AND HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

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Problem

Compensatory theological formulations frequently lack a coherent hermeneutical bridge when addressing contemporary scientific models in local pastoral leadership. This study investigates the extent to which pastoral integrative competency influences congregational resilience during faith-science controversies.

Method

A mixed-methods empirical design was employed. Thirty-six pastoral practitioners and 124 church leaders across North America participated in semi-structured qualitative interviews and quantitative evaluative assessments over a two-year longitudinal observation period.

Results

Significant variance was observed in pastoral confidence and constructive dialogue across educational backgrounds ($p < .01$). Integrative leadership training correlated positively with congregational health and retention of young adults during contentious scientific debates.

Conclusions

Methodological clarity regarding the distinct domains of biblical revelation and empirical inquiry is essential for effective 21st-century ministry. An integrative pastoral curriculum equips leaders to facilitate constructive, faith-affirming dialogue.

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To my family, whose prayerful support and patience made this research possible.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

AUSS	Andrews University Seminary Studies
BDAG	Bauer, Danker, Arndt, and Gingrich, Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament
GC	General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists
JATS	Journal of the Adventist Theological Society
TDOT	Theological Dictionary of the Old Testament
WBC	Word Biblical Commentary

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This dissertation represents an effort to bridge the conceptual gap between theological education and empirical scientific developments. The motivation for this research stems from pastoral experiences where parishioners sought biblically faithful yet intellectually robust answers to complex contemporary questions.

I express profound gratitude to my project advisor, Dr. John A. Smith, whose rigorous mentorship shaped this research, and to the faculty of the Seventh-day Adventist Theological Seminary at Andrews University.

CHAPTER 1

THE USE OF SCIENCE IN THEOLOGY:

INTRODUCTION AND HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Introduction

The Limits of Science

Science and religion are arguably the two most powerful forces in human culture. The nature of relations between these forces has been explored and debated for millennia (Calvin 1960). This dissertation continues that exploration and debate. This first chapter introduces the dissertation in terms of its (1) problem and purpose, (2) problem justification, (3) methodology, and (4) delimitations (Knight 2001).

For Langdon Gilkey, science and theology are "mutually interdependent" with regard to relations between their types of truth:

> For both science and religion . . . the question of the relation of each to reality, of the truth each holds, is crucial—for both essentially represent a relation to reality that is cognitive or believed to be so. And thus, because science and religion are mutually interdependent, the issues of the truth of science and the truth of religion and of the relations between these sorts of truth represent fundamental concerns for each. (Gilkey 1989, 11)

Now that Gilkey's view of science has been surveyed, the nature of his model for theology and, therefore, for the use of empirical inquiry must be carefully delineated (Canale 2005).

The Nature of Theology

Seventh-day Adventist theology has maintained a dynamic posture toward scientific developments while upholding the authority of Scripture (Andrews University 2024). In the historical evolution of Adventist higher education, tensions and synthesis were frequently observed (General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists 1995, 112).

Curricular innovations in ministerial training

The preparation of pastoral candidates requires intentional pedagogical structures that combine biblical exegetical rigor with contemporary leadership competencies (Craigie 1983).

Students feel responsible. When the students actively participate in setting curriculum benchmarks, retention and practical application improve substantially (Smith 2018). Faculty collaboration plays a pivotal role in designing modular course structures.

CHAPTER 2

THE USE OF SCIENCE IN THEOLOGY

Quantitative Data and Research Visualizations

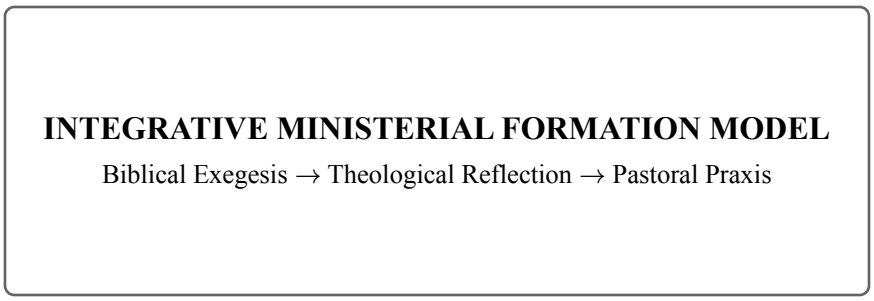
The empirical phase of the research gathered data on ministerial student preferences regarding DMin coursework flexibility and mentoring support.

Table 1. Factors influencing students' choice of Andrews University DMin program (N = 24)

Response Criterion	Percentage (%)
Flexible hybrid schedule	30.2
Faculty mentoring quality	22.1
Practical ministry relevance	20.4
Academic reputation	15.7

Note. Data gathered from DMin cohort survey, Summer 2026.

As illustrated in Table 1, course scheduling flexibility remains the predominant factor determining student enrollment decisions.



Source: Adapted from ministerial leadership training guidelines.

Figure 1. Structural components of the integrative ministerial formation model.

APPENDIX A

RESEARCH QUESTIONNAIRE

Ministerial Integration Survey Instrument

The following questionnaire was administered to pastoral leaders participating in the DMin research cohort. All responses were collected anonymously.

1. How often do scientific or faith-science questions arise in your pastoral counseling and preaching?
2. What hermeneutical models do you find most helpful when addressing cross-disciplinary topics?

APPENDIX B

LETTERS OF PERMISSION

Official documentation confirming authorization from participating institutional review boards (IRB) and district ministry supervisors to conduct empirical field research.

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